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Geomancy in the Islamic World

When Francis Bacon (d. 1626) valorized artificial divination over natural as an essential component of his scientific method, he was referring in particular to the Arabic art of *geomancy*, third in popularity only to astrology and oneiromancy throughout the early modern Western (Islamo-Judeo-Christian) world. Indeed, due to its early incorporation of astrological correspondences, it was often considered a form of "terrestrial astrology" requiring much less astronomical expertise while remaining richly informative. As a complex divinatory science based on a binary code, geomancy stands precise cognate to the ancient Chinese *I Ching*, but commanded in its prime a far greater territorial spread. It was – and in many cases still is – regularly practiced as a single tradition from Fez, Paris and Timbuktu to Kashgar, Kabul and Delhi, and calved simpler versions throughout sub-Saharan Africa (*ifa*, *gara* and *sikidy*) and thence the western hemisphere that remain very much in use.

The Latin term *geomantia* imprecisely translates the Arabic *ʿilm al-raml*, the "science of sand"; like other Arabic terms for the art (*khaṭṭ al-raml*, *ḍarb*, *ṭarq*), this refers to its original procedure of drawing 16 random series of lines in the sand or dirt to generate the first four tetragrams of a geomantic reading. (Confusingly, in modern English usage geomancy can also refer to the Chinese art of *feng shui*, though this is a misnomer; as a system of divining the subtle currents of the earth for the purposes of building or burying, it is more accurately termed "topomancy.") As with *I Ching* trigrams, the four lines of a geomantic figure (*shakl*) are generated by the odd (*fard*) or even (*zawj*) result of each line, creating a binary code represented as either one dot (*nuqṭa*) or two dots respectively – hence the science's alternative name of *ʿilm al-nuqṭa* or *ʿilm al-niqāṭ*, whence its close association with lettrism (*ʿilm al-ḥurūf*), coeval Arabic twin to Hebrew kabbalah. This binary code is then deployed according to set procedures to capture the flux patterns of the four elemental energies (fire, air, water, earth) as a means to divine past, present and future events, and indeed the status of every thing or being in the sublunar realm. Emilie Savage-Smith (1993) summarizes the geomantic method as follows:

> The divination is accomplished by forming and then interpreting a design, called a geomantic tableau, consisting of 16 positions, each of which is occupied by a geomantic figure. The figures occupying the first four positions are determined by marking 16 horizontal lines of dots on a piece of paper or a dust board. Each row of dots is examined to determine if it is odd or even and is then represented by one or two dots accordingly. Each figure is then formed of a vertical column of four marks, each of which is either one or two dots. The first four figures, generated by lines made while the questioner concentrates upon the question, are placed side by side in a row from right to left. From these four figures the remaining twelve positions in the tableau are produced according to set procedures. Various interpretative methods are advocated by geomancers for reading the tableau, often depending upon the nature of the question asked.

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Fig. 36: A typical geomantic tableau (Shams al-Dīn Khafrī, Risāla dar Raml, Princeton, University Library MS New Series 1177/2, fol. 24b). Photo credits: Matthew Melvin-Koushki.

From right to left, the first four figures in the top row are termed Mothers (*ummahāt*), which are combined to produce the second four in the same row, termed Daughters (*banāt*); the four figures the Mothers and Daughters produce in the next row are termed Nieces (*ḥafīdāt*, *mutawallidāt*); and the Nieces are combined to produce the *zawāʾid* in the rows below: first, the Right and Left Witnesses (*shāhidayn*), which in turn produce the Judge (*mīzān*) in the 15^{th} position at the bottom of the geomantic tableau or shield chart (*takht*). In the 16^{th} and final position, usually drawn below and to the right of the Judge or otherwise bracketed off, is the Result of the Result, or Reconciler (*ʿāqibat al-ʿāqiba*), produced by the combination of the first Mother and the Judge.

The number of possible combinations of figures in a geomantic tableau is 16^4, or 65,536 in all. Each of the 16 geomantic figures acquired a full suite of specific elemental, astrological, calendrical, numerical, lettrist, humoral, physiognomical and other correspondences; the first 12 houses of the geomantic chart were likewise mapped onto the 12 planetary houses, and occasionally constructed in the form of a horoscope. Detailed information can thus be derived from the figures and their relationships about virtually any aspect of human experience, whether physical, mental or spiritual, whether past, present or future.

In the Islamicate world, where the science originated, geomancy was typically associated in the first place with the prophets Idrīs (Enoch or Hermes) and Daniel and the Indian sage Ṭumṭum (Dindimus), not to mention a number of other standard occultist authorities, especially ʿAlī ibn Abī Ṭālib (d. 661) and Jaʿfar al-Ṣādiq (d. 765), the first and sixth Shiʿi Imams respectively; prooftexts from the Quran and Hadith were also frequently adduced. Intellectual genealogies of geomancy in Arabic and Persian works on the subject thus presuppose a pre-Islamic Near Eastern or Indian origin, as well as an early North African Berber connection; the otherwise unknown Abū ʿAbd Allāh Muḥammad al-Zanātī (fl. before 1232), presumably of the Berber Zanāta tribe, is acclaimed as its first major Arabic exponent. Later Christian authors too associate the science with various venerable prophets of antiquity, including Hermes and even Seth.

While geomancy fell out of mainstream use in Enlightenment Europe, it experienced no such decline in the "un-Enlightened" Islamicate world, and particularly its vast Persianate subset, where occultist traditions enjoyed smoother continuity and wider practice. Along with astrologers and lettrists, geomancers were in high demand at imperial and regional courts during the early modern period, especially the Ottoman, Safavid and Mughal; in particular, geomancy was often combined with astrology and lettrism for military-strategic purposes. And well into the modern period we find vigorous testimony that the science was still considered a scholarly staple from the Maghreb to India. In nineteenth-century Samarqand and Bukhara, for instance, surviving miscellany notebooks kept by judges and physicians suggest that they often employed geomantic readings to help them decide court cases or diagnose patients. Geomancy's popularity remains unabated in Iran today, though frequent abuse by fraudsters has made its practice into something of a social problem; as a result, *rammālī*, "geomancing," often tantamount to "hocus-pocus" in popular usage, is now legally punishable by a fine and up to seven years' imprisonment. Yet Persian and Arabic manuals on the science have continued to be published, even by preeminent religious scholars like ʿAllāma Ṭabāṭabāʾī (d. 1981) – an index of the great depth to which its prestige was ingrained in Islamicate learned culture over the past millennium, the many colonialist ruptures of that culture all notwithstanding.

As with many Arabic sciences, especially of the occult variety, geomancy likewise boomed in popularity among the humanists of the European Renaissance as an obvious technological application of the *prisca sapientia*; the manuals of (pseudo-) Heinrich Cornelius Agrippa (d. 1535), Christophe de Cattan (fl. 1558) and Robert Fludd (d. 1637) represent the high water mark. But here too the Arabic-to-Latin transmission was very partial, and early modern Latinate geomancy remained largely pinned to those texts that happened to be done into Latin, inexpertly, during the translation movement of the twelfth and thirteenth centuries, beginning with Hugo of Santalla (fl. 1145), with a few later inputs. Given such a piecemeal reception, various technical applications and procedures of Arabic geomancy became so garbled in Latin as to be unusable, and most of those that became standard in the Islamicate world remained unknown to the Latin Christianate. Byzantine scholars, by contrast, showed interest in contemporary developments in the science (under transliterations like *rabolion* and *ramplion*) through the sixteenth century; some even translated directly from Persian treatises. But the later Russian Orthodox reception was even more abbreviated and anxious as to possible heterodoxy.

inputs via Hebrew. (Unsurprisingly, the healthy Judeo-Arabic and Hebrew geomantic tradition itself remained more closely tied to Arabic developments from its inception, as shown already by geomantic fragments in the Cairo Geniza [↗ Saar, Divination in the Cairo Genizah].)

Most notably, Arabo-Persian geomancy in its mature form is predicated on the deployment of cycles (sg. *dāʾira*), or specific orders of the 16 figures (sg. *taskīn*), to reveal with precision such categories of data as the following: numbers, letters, days, months, years, astral bodies and divisions, body parts, physical and facial characteristics, minerals, precious stones, plants and plant products, animals and animal products, birds, fruits, tastes, colors, places, directions, regions, topographies, genders, social classes, nations, weapons, diseases, etc. These cycles are successively deployed until the desired information is obtained. In Latin and Latinate vernaculars, however, one of the few geomantic cycles to survive transmission, that of the letter (*ḥarf*), for telling the names of people, places and things, is both tied to the order of the Arabic alphabet and too corrupt to be of use to the modern geomancer, according to recent testimony. That said, Renaissance Latinate geomancy, however truncated, survived through at least the eighteenth century, and was revived – albeit in even more truncated form – by the Hermetic Order of the Golden Dawn around the turn of the twentieth. Recent English geomantic manuals, especially that of John Michael Greer, suggest a renewed popularity in Anglo-American culture today. And again, the various derivative, similarly simplified forms of African geomancy are even more prevalent in both the Old World and the New.

To understand the importance of geomancy to the history of Western science, however, we must turn to the early modern Persianate realm, where it reached its apex of sophistication and complexity through eager imperial patronage. Epistemologically, Persian geomancy came to occupy the midpoint between astrology and alchemy. The conceptual and sociopolitical association of the science of the sand with the science of the stars is exemplified by the fact that the professional designation *munajjim*, court astronomer-astrologer, in some cases became synonymous with *rammāl*, court geomancer, so frequently was mastery of both sciences combined in the same individual. By the same token, in Persian encyclopedias of the sciences, though not in Arabic or Latin ones, geomancy was classified as a *mathematical* science, together with astrology, from the twelfth century onward, when the eminent philosopher-theologian Fakhr al-Dīn al-Rāzī (d. 1210) introduced it to a persophone readership. This epistemic seachange, in turn, heralded its great interest to early modern Iranian philosophers and astronomers, from Naṣīr al-Dīn al-Ṭūsī (d. 1274) to Shams al-Dīn Khafrī (d. 1535), as a scientific means of corroborating Neopythagorean-Neoplatonic emanationist cosmology. Even the Timurid sultan-scientist Ulugh Beg (r. 1409–1449) himself, founder of the Samarqand Observatory, was partial to this terrestrial astrology. But geomancy was just as frequently classed as a *physiological* science (*ʿilm-i ṭabāyiʿ*), and hence a natural correlate to both alchemy and medicine: for all surviving Arabic and Persian manuals stress the status of the 16 figures as maps of the four elements and four qualities (and by extension the four humors) in their perpetual reconfigurations – whence geomancy's claim over all beings and events in the sublunar, physical realm. As adepts of a simultaneously terrestial and celestial science, moreover, Muslim geomancers developed various forms of geomantic magic to further put their starry-earthy art to scientific-imperial use. Given such wide and sustained prestige, surviving copies of Arabic and Persian geomantic manuals outstrip Latinate ones by at least an order of magnitude: over a thousand geomantic manuscripts are preserved in Iran alone, while mere dozens remain in the libraries of Western Europe and North America.

Geomancy, in sum, developed from obscure origins to become a mature and mainstream mathematical-natural occult science of wide appeal throughout the early modern Western world, with reverberations to the present. Predicated on a Neopythagorean-Neoplatonic system and animated by the twin principles of correspondence and secondary causation, geomancy was of particular interest to thinkers and rulers throughout the Persianate world during the thirteenth to seventeenth-century imperial moment most especially. Its great philosophical-scientific virtue lay in its ability to empirically support the cosmology of its scholarly practitioners; its professional virtue lay in its status as magnet for royal patronage. For Mughal, Safavid, Ottoman and other elites, the science became part and parcel of the performance of sainthood and sacral kingship because it promises granular, prophetic-grade insight into and thus power over history. That is to say, such sciences of divination, as the very term connotes, were crucial to the quest for *divinization* pursued by many Turko-Mongol Perso-Islamic sovereigns and other messianic claimants in the run-up to the Islamic millennium (1592) – hence the unprecedented and unparalleled sophistication of sixteenth-century Persian geomantic manuals, dimly reflected in their contemporary Latin, French and English cognates. Thus did the Iranian émigré Hidāyat Allāh Munajjim Shīrāzī (fl. 1593) write his manual – the most comprehensive ever produced in the Western tradition – to celebrate the Mughal emperor Akbar's (r. 1556–1605) accession as millennial sovereign; thus did Abū l-Fażl ʿAllāmī (d. 1602), chief architect of the new Mughal imperial culture, require that all students and state officials be versed in the science.

Despite its deficient reception in Western Europe, and the destruction of much of its scholarly prestige throughout the Islamicate world under the brunt of Enlightened colonialism, geomancy – embraced by Bacon and a host of his Muslim, Jewish, Christian and African peers – remains essential to any history of Western science worth the name: for it pursues, in the most literal and direct way possible, the reading of the earth itself as a mathematical Book.

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